THE MATERNITY METHOD

NCLEX CHEAT SHEET

Postpartum Care

Maternal & Newborn › Postpartum

The Big Picture The **postpartum period** (about 6 weeks) is when mom's body **returns to non-pregnant** state. Assess **head to toe**, catch **bleeding, infection, clots, and mood changes** early, and **teach** while she's ready to learn.

KNOW THE NUMBERS

1 cm / day **Fundus** drops below umbilicus	**< 38 °C** Temp OK in the **first 24 hrs**	**6–8 hrs** **First void** after birth	**1 pad / hr** **Soaked**: hemorrhage	**2 wks** **Baby blues** should fade

Fundus

- Right after birth: **firm, midline**, at or near the umbilicus
- Drops about **1 cm (1 finger) a day**
- **Not palpable** by about 2 weeks
- **Boggy → massage** until firm
- **Shifted to the right → full bladder** → void or catheter

Lochia

- **Rubra:** red, days **1–3**
- **Serosa:** pink-brown, days **4–10**
- **Alba:** yellow-white, **day 10 to about 6 wks**
- Small clots OK; **large clots** or soaked pad in 1 hr → report
- **Foul smell** → infection

Steady trickle of **bright red** blood with a **firm** fundus → think **laceration**.

MEMORY HACK · HEAD-TO-TOE CHECK

Every postpartum assessment: Breasts → Fundus → Bladder → Bowel → Bleeding → Bottom → Legs → Mood

Bottom
REEDA: Redness, Edema, Ecchymosis, Drainage, Approximation

Bladder
Void in 6–8 hrs; watch for **retention**

Legs
One-sided swelling, warmth, pain = **DVT**

Mood
Bonding, sleep, sadness, **safety**

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Comfort & Teaching

Area	What to do	Teach
Perineum	**Ice packs first 24 hrs**, then **sitz baths**; peri bottle; witch hazel, numbing spray	Wipe **front to back**; change pads often
Breasts: breastfeeding	**Feed often**; warmth before, cold after for engorgement	Good **latch** prevents sore nipples
Breasts: not breastfeeding	**Snug bra**, ice packs, **cabbage leaves**	**Avoid** pumping or warm showers on breasts
Bowels	**Stool softeners**, fluids, fiber, walking	Don't strain; first BM may take a few days
After cesarean	**Splint** with a pillow, **walk early**, incentive spirometer, check incision	No lifting heavier than baby; report redness or drainage

Mood Changes After Birth

Baby Blues

- **Very common**
- Starts day **2–3**
- Tearful, moody, but **still functions**
- **Gone by 2 weeks**: support, rest

Postpartum Depression

- Lasts **> 2 weeks**, anytime in the first year
- Sad, hopeless, **can't function**, trouble bonding
- Screen (e.g., **Edinburgh**); therapy, meds; refer

Postpartum Psychosis

- **Rare emergency**, usually first weeks
- **Hallucinations**, confusion, paranoia
- Risk of harm to self or baby → **don't leave her alone**

Before Discharge

- **Rh– mom, Rh+ baby** → RhoGAM within **72 hrs**
- **Rubella non-immune** → **MMR**; avoid pregnancy **4 weeks**
- **Tdap** if not given in pregnancy
- Birth control plan; sex when bleeding stops and she feels ready (often 4–6 wks)
- **Phases:** taking-in (talks about birth) → **taking-hold (best time to teach)** → letting-go

Vital Sign Clues

- **Low HR** (50–70) is common early
- **Fast HR** → bleeding or infection
- **Temp ≥ 38 °C after 24 hrs** → infection
- **BP up** → postpartum preeclampsia (possible up to 6 wks)
- **BP down** → bleeding

WARNING SIGNS · TEACH: CALL 911 OR COME IN

Chest pain or trouble breathing · **Seizure** · **Thoughts of hurting** herself or baby · Soaking **1 pad an hour** or big clots · **Incision** red, opening, or draining · **Red, swollen, painful leg** · **Fever ≥ 38 °C (100.4 °F)** · **Severe headache** or vision changes

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☆ MUST-KNOW FOR THE NCLEX

- **Boggy fundus → massage first.** Displaced to the right → empty the bladder.
- Lochia goes **rubra → serosa → alba**; it should never go back to bright red.
- **Taking-hold** is the best teaching phase.
- **Baby blues < 2 wks** = normal. Longer, or can't function = **PPD**. Hallucinations = **psychosis** (emergency).
- **MMR** postpartum if non-immune; **RhoGAM** within 72 hrs if indicated.

QUICK CHECK · TEST YOURSELF

1. On day 2 after birth, the fundus should be about ____ cm below the umbilicus.
2. A fundus that is firm but shifted to the right means a full _____.
3. Pink-brown lochia on day 6 is called lochia _____.
4. The best postpartum phase for teaching is _____.
5. After MMR, avoid pregnancy for ____ weeks.

Answers: 1. 2 · 2. bladder · 3. serosa · 4. taking-hold · 5. 4

For study use only. Always follow facility protocols, current guidelines, and provider orders.